

| By Priya Sahgal |

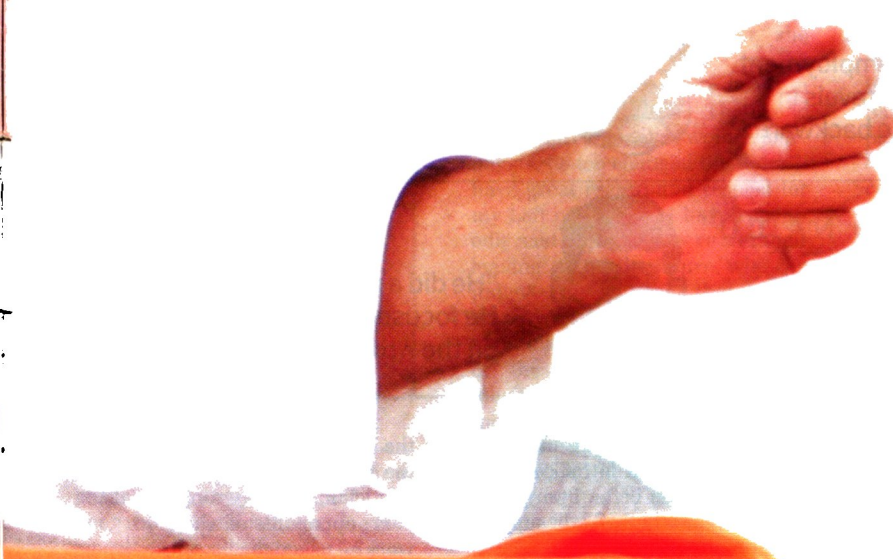
Suddenly, there is a surge called Rahul Gandhi. Chroniclers of Congress lore would record that it was during the merciless summer of 2009 that the Gandhi scion finally stepped out of the sheltering shadow of his mother and began speaking his mind—and the party's too. For the last five years, it was the story of a reluctant Crown Prince caught between the call of ancestry and the challenges of politics. There have been many soft launches of Brand Rahul, beginning with when he became a party general secretary two years ago. Or when he emerged as the star campaigner during the

last round of state elections. Or when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh offered him a place in the Cabinet but he politely declined. Each time, the young Gandhi failed to seize the moment, pleading inexperience. He was a permanent work in progress. An apprentice with my-time-has-not-come modesty. In an age when a freshman senator with barely four years in public life could become the pres-

ident of America, the argument of inexperience betrayed a kind of diffidence. That was yesterday. Today, he is showing the ferocity of an attack dog and the calm of a policy wonk and the authority of a leader who knows his place in the party—and in the minds of the desperate legion of Congressmen. Sleeves rolled back, he impatiently pushes his glasses back on his forehead and dashes about the

countryside with a brief that goes far beyond that of a mere general secretary. Whether it is to the shirtless in the remote village or to the media in conference halls, the 38-year-old MP from Amethi has become the most audible voice of India's Grand Old Party.

Shall we say the Rahul era has finally begun, when the finer points of party policies will no longer be debated behind closed



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gress campaign from the front. His statements confound his party and confuse his enemies.